

Firefighters in L.A. Race to Corral Inferno as Gusts Ease



Destruction from the Palisades fire on Thursday. The largest of the fires, it has burned more than 17,000 hilly acres along the coast between Santa Monica and Malibu.

Blazes May Grow Again as Wind Resurges

This article is by **Corina Knoll, Soumya Karlamangla and Michael Levenson.**

LOS ANGELES — Firefighters, aided by calmer winds and planes and helicopters dropping water, were racing on Thursday to try to gain control of roaring wildfires that have upended life in Los Angeles, incinerated neighborhoods, driven thousands from their homes and killed at least five people.

Mayor Karen Bass of Los Angeles said that the Sunset fire, which started Wednesday evening and raced across the Hollywood Hills, was now 100 percent contained. Hundreds of firefighters worked overnight to control the fire, which had reached 43 acres and had prompted fears that it could spread to the center of the Los Angeles metropolitan area.

But officials warned that the fires remained potentially deadly and unpredictable and that the two largest and most destructive ones, the Palisades and Eaton fires, were completely uncontained. With dangerous wind gusts expected to return and no rain in the forecast, officials said that the fires could spread even farther and that other fires could start.

The scale of the destruction, across diverse communities of every socioeconomic status, is already without precedent. The fires have put 360,000 people under mandatory evacuation orders, federal officials said, and have scorched more than 30,000 acres, equivalent to nearly 23,000 football fields.

The Palisades fire appears to have destroyed more than 5,000 homes, businesses and other structures, according to fire officials who conducted aerial surveys of the region. The Eaton fire may have destroyed 4,000 to 5,000

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Catastrophe Cuts Across Geography and Class

By SHAWN HUBLER

It has long been a local article of faith: Southern California disasters are rarely as sweeping as they seem.

Delaware and Rhode Island could fit, with room to spare, in Los Angeles County. A drive from Pacific Palisades to Pasadena takes nearly an hour, even without traffic. When the Los Angeles riots erupted in 1992, Americans recoiled at the fires silhouetting the downtown skyline. Not shown were the jacaranda-lined streets and placid suburbs where the rest of Southern California watched

Sign of a New and Less Manageable Future in Los Angeles

the mayhem on TV.

This time, it was different.

In a furious assault that began Tuesday morning and continued into Thursday, a wind-and-wild-fire monster attacked a metropolis of 4,753 square miles and nearly 10 million people, whipping up flames that tore through communities of every socioeconomic status and stripe.

Mansions were reduced to ash in Pacific Palisades, a West Los Angeles celebrity enclave. Subdivisions burned to the ground 35 miles to the east in the tidy suburb of Altadena. Ranch hands in rural Sylmar, 25 miles to the north, fled into the fiery night, leading horses. New homeowners in freshly built developments hours away in inland communities like Pomona braced for evacuations as 59-mile-per-hour winds rattled the windowpanes and palm trees.

As of Thursday, the fires had claimed at least five lives and may have destroyed more than 9,000 buildings, according to early as-

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Pacific Palisades evacuees, many of whom lost their homes, gathered for Mass at Our Lady of the Angels in Los Angeles Thursday.



Carole Wilbourn with a patient named Finn in 2014.

CAROLE WILBOURN 1940-2024

Psychotherapy For Narcissists That Go Meow

By PENELOPE GREEN

Carole Wilbourn, a self-described cat therapist, who was known for her skill in decoding the emotional life of cats, as confounding as that would seem to be, died on Dec. 23 at her home in Manhattan. She was 84.

Her death was confirmed by her sister Gail Mutrux.

Ms. Wilbourn's patients shredded sofas, toilet paper and romantic partners. They soiled rugs and beds. They galloped over their sleeping humans in the wee hours. They hissed at babies, dogs and other cats. They chewed electrical wires. They sulked in closets and went on hunger strikes.

They suffered from childhood trauma, low self-esteem, anxiety, depression, jealousy and just plain rage. And Ms. Wilbourn, who was self-taught — in college she had studied (human) psychology and majored in education —

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Trump Seeking A Disease to Pin On Immigrants

By ZOLAN KANNO-YOUNGS and HAMED ALEAZIZ

WASHINGTON — President-elect Donald J. Trump is likely to justify his plans to seal off the border with Mexico by citing a public health emergency from immigrants bringing disease into the United States.

Now he just has to find one.

Mr. Trump last invoked public health restrictions, known as Title 42, in the early days of the pandemic in 2020, when the coronavirus was tearing across the globe. As he prepares to enter office again, Mr. Trump has no such public health disaster to point to.

Still, his advisers have spent recent months trying to find the right disease to build their case, according to four people familiar with the discussions. They have looked at tuberculosis and other respiratory diseases as options and have asked allies inside the Border Patrol for examples of illnesses that are being detected among migrants.

They also have considered trying to rationalize Title 42 by arguing broadly that migrants at the border come from various countries and may carry unfamiliar disease — an assertion that echoes a racist notion with a long history in the United States that minorities transmit infections.

Mr. Trump's team did not respond to a request for comment.

A plan to invoke the border restrictions based on sporadic cases of illness or even a vague fear of illness — rather than a major disease outbreak or pandemic — would amount to a radical use of

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Lofty Tribute to a Public Servant and Humble Grandfather

By PETER BAKER

WASHINGTON — The nation bade farewell to former President Jimmy Carter on Thursday with a majestic state funeral for a man who saw himself as anything but, remembering a peanut farmer from Georgia who rose to the heights of power and used it to fight for justice, eradicate disease and wage peace, not war.

Five living presidents and a broad array of other leaders gathered at Washington National Cathedral to pay tribute to the 39th president, not only for his accomplishments during four years in the nation's highest office but also for his relentless humanitarian work in the four decades after he left the White House.

"Throughout his life, he showed us what it means to be a practitioner of good works, a good and faithful servant of God and of the people," President Biden said in a eulogy, delivered just 11 days before he too leaves office as a one-term Democrat. "Today, many think he was from a bygone era.

Five Presidents Gather to Remember Carter

But in reality, he saw well into the future."

The grand service in the ornate cathedral on a hill was a classic Washington spectacle with all the rituals of a presidential passing and all the intrigues of a political convention. As organs played and choirs sang, many had their

minds on the soon-to-be-inaugurated president as much as the one in the flag-draped coffin. Mourners craned their necks to gauge the body language as President-elect Donald J. Trump sat near his four peers, none of whom care for him and most of whom ignored him.

Adding to the unspoken drama, two leading figures from countries that Mr. Trump has threatened in recent days sat barely 30 feet away: Prime Minister Justin Trudeau of Canada and former

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A majestic state funeral held at Washington National Cathedral on Thursday was the pinnacle of America's honors to Jimmy Carter.

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Call Renews Ethics Scrutiny

President-elect Donald J. Trump called Justice Samuel A. Alito Jr. hours before asking the court to block his sentencing in his hush-money case.

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Bracing for Loss of TikTok

Billions in advertising flows through TikTok, which could be banned in the U.S. as soon as Jan. 19. Brands and creators are racing to prepare.

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Cotton Bowl Quarterbacks

The national semifinal between Ohio State and Texas will feature signal-callers who took their first college-football snaps at other schools.

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A More Magical Brooklyn

A new club hosts weekly shows by the world's best magicians in an intimate setting. It's part of a resurgence of magic shows in New York.

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